

FNB AOTY Hackathon 2026

EVENT BRIEFING & SCHEDULE OF ACTIVITIES

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DATE: Sat, 24 Oct 2026 11:43

Generated through the Sonke Platform

Introduction & Guidelines

> Set to start on Fri, 23 Oct 2026 08:30 and ends on Sun, 25 Oct 2026 17:00. The official hashtag is **#FNBHackathon**.

NOTE: The numbers above will change as the event proceeds with more teams created or participants having joined.

WHAT TO KNOW	SOME DETAILS	ACTION FROM WENA (YOU)
Okay, I'm here on Sonke – now what?	This is the platform used for the team creation and submission	Click the **CREATE TEAM** button above to profile (create) a team - make sure your mates haven't, otherwise they must add you to the team.
How does this link to FNB App of the Year Awards?	At the awards, there is a **Best Hackathon Solution** for apps built from this hackathon. Judged same away as all the awards – ***there are no presentations for the hackathon, just submit***.	You need to build the app submit by 26 Oct 23:59 – no code must be uploaded but do provide link to your Git repo.
Is it important to create a team?	ABSOLUTELY! Even if working along, you need to create a team.	Use the button above and then fill in the information
Okay... So how do I add my team members?	After creating the team, you will see a button named "ADD TEAM MEMBERS" on the Dashboard or team page —> Search person (even by email) —> Click Add To My Team and that's it.	You must create a team first and team members must have a Sonke account – invite them through INVITE MATES link on the left panel.
What are the important things this weekend?	You need join the sessions including opening here; Submit requirements on the Programme (full schedule to be shared). Connect with organisers and mentors here.	Keep track of the Schedule – click Programme above.
Any limits to know?	You may use any technologies to build. GenAI is not limited but you are urged not to outsource all your thinking; No team limit set.	It's an apps-only hackathon, build that winning app, fam.
What is defined as an app for the hackathon?	Strictly no static websites or mock ups; You may build a web app (needs to process user data in real-time of need); If its a bot on WhatsApp or similar – you still need to have database plan.	If its an APK, please sign it and confirm that it can be installed
What about existing apps?	You need work on at least one feature during the hackathon.	Let organisers know through the updates in team page.

Do we need to host or publish?	Yes – web apps need to be on a live platform (you may use open source platforms); No – there is no need for the app to be on the app store, just upload APK or any usable build file.	Make sure that the judges are able to test your app. Create a **demo account** and add to slides.
How do we get mentors help, sana?	Use the **NEED HELP** button above; Use General channel; Join the mentor calls before. Generally, join main call **here**.	Be descriptive on what you need
VIDEO NEEDED BY SATURDAY 12:00PM	You are required to submit a 20s Hustle Pitch video (*SELL THE APP OFFERING*) – feedback will come through email too.	Record yourself selling the app and submit. A button to upload this video will appear from Friday 23rd.
What is needed for submission?	**Presentation deck / slides** [including: User Journey Story; Technical Architecture, Demo account details – link and login details]; App build file (e.g. APK). Fill in **Lean Business Canvas** in team page; Fill in **SSDL(security); Updates** before midnight each day.	NB: You cannot submit without create a team first – create the team or be added by your team mates.
MENTOR CALL: AI & Software Development	Want to align your solution to an AI model? Want to strengthen intelligence? Got code issues? Join **here**.	Available 23 - 25 Oct: Join the call whenever you need assistance or to engage with others.
MENTOR CALL: Ideas, Innovation & Business	Want to see if the solution make sense? Want to make business sense? Want to make the solution more unique? Join **here**.	Available 23 - 25 Oct: Join the call whenever you need assistance or to engage with others.
MENTOR CALL: Architecture, Backend and Security	Want to build a solid architecture for the solution? Want to build for scale? Don't know how to integrate security? Join **here**.	Available 23 - 25 Oct: Join the call whenever you need assistance or to engage with others.

VERY IMPORTANT: In order to be judged, all teams must be profiled (even if wotking solo).

Challenges

Access to higher education

Problem statement
How might technology help young South Africans find suitable study pathways, compare funding options, complete applications and remain supported from acceptance through graduation?

Possible focus areas
Applications, bursaries and NSFAS guidance; cost planning; student wellness; academic persistence; connectivity and accessible learning.

Youth employment and work readiness

Problem statement
How might we shorten the distance between young people and meaningful income by translating skills into credible profiles, practical experience, work opportunities and career mobility?

Possible focus areas
Skills verification; entry-level matching; micro-internships; mentorship; informal experience; transport and data barriers.

Youth entrepreneurship and small-business growth

Problem statement
How might digital tools help young founders and township or rural businesses start, trade, get paid, manage cash flow and reach formal markets?

Possible focus areas
Business registration; digital payments; bookkeeping; procurement access; market links; funding readiness and fraud protection.

Financial inclusion and money confidence

Problem statement
How might we make everyday money management simpler, safer and more useful for people with irregular incomes, limited financial knowledge or limited access to formal services?

Possible focus areas

Budgeting; saving; responsible credit; low-data tools; multilingual support; scam awareness; accessible design.

Safer communities and gender-based violence response

Problem statement
How might technology help people find trusted support, document incidents safely, access emergency help and strengthen prevention without placing survivors at greater risk?

Possible focus areas
Privacy-first reporting; verified services; discreet access; referral pathways; community education; responsible data governance.

Climate resilience and essential services

Problem statement
How might communities use data and digital services to prepare for disruptions, reduce household costs and improve access to water, energy, transport and food?

Possible focus areas
Local alerts; service reporting; resource sharing; energy and water savings; food access; climate-smart small businesses.

Judging Criteria

#	Title	Description	Weight
1	Product	• Is the app a complete solution or does is it far from completion? • Is it polished and does it work in a way the user would expect? • Does it do what it is meant to do, and resolve the needs of the challenges it addresses? • Is there a market need for the application? • Does it have traction?	10
2	Creativity	• Is it a new application or service that has been created? • How creative is the approach? • Is it contributing towards the improvement of society or business in some new way? • Is it commercially, socially, politically, or personally appealing, relevant and exciting? • Is it freshly entertaining, a new approach to an old problem or a better way to do something more effectively?	10
3	Usability	• Is the app easy to use? • Is there a clarity, simplicity and intuitive feel of how the app works and what to do next?	10
4	Sustainability	• What is the potential of the application and the team of developers behind it? • Can the app be taken to the next level? • Is there a potential path to revenue with the app?	10
5	Impact	• How much impact does the application have? • What kind of problem does it solve – a big or small one? • What is the level of indispensability and importance of the app?	10
6	Presentation	• How well did the team communicate their idea/app? • Were they effective in telling their story and did they convey the importance and relevance of the mobile application to society?	10
7	Intelligence	Can the app “think” for itself, forecast, and predict the user’s likely future behaviour by analyzing patterns in data inputs?	10

The Programme

DAY 1: 23 October 2026

JOIN THE OPENING: https://www.appoftheyear.co.za from 10:00

You may also search FNB App of the Year on YouTube directly.

10:30–10:45	**Sponsor opening address**	**FNB**
10:45–11:05	Challenge reveal (ensuring that you understand the requirements)	Mrs Sthembiso Dabula-Mabotja
11:05–11:20	Winner to builder	Previous winner / founder
11:20–11:30	Energy break: Code or Cap?	MC + participants (prizes to be given)
11:30–11:55	What the Hack? – understanding the flow	Ms Yolisa Dumezweni
11:55–12:10	Build responsibly	Accenture / tech specialist
12:10–12:25	Mentor speed introductions	MC
12:25–12:40	Live Q&A and first sponsor prize draw	MC + sponsor representatives
12:40–12:45	Official start of the hackathon declaration	MC

At this point, the hackathon will move to a teams at work and you may join **the hackathon meeting** a call.

DESIGNATED MEETING CALLS

MAIN CALL MEETING (23 - 25 OCT 2026):
https://connect.gklink.co/meeting/1D0Y9ZO0HJI0

Open all weekend from 12:00PM. In this call, the organisers will be there to assist you with various things.

12:45 - 20:00	**Hack-Away**	**Working to build the app with assistance from the mentors. Here is how to get assistance.**
20:00 - 20:30	Update of Team Profile – ensure that your project overview is well in order.	**All teams, click EDIT TEAM PROFILE on the Dashboard or from your team page.**
20:30 - 23:00	Hack-Away	Continue working with assistance from mentors.
23:00 - 00:00	**Progress Update**	**Teams – though through Sonke in the team page. Click NEW UPDATE / UPDATES on states. Be clear on where your solution is.**

DAY 2: 24 October 2026

Like the first day, there is a live watch on www.appoftheyear.co.za for key briefing and knowledge.

Time	Segment	Lead	Purpose / production notes
09:00–09:08	Wake-up countdown	MC	Music, live social wall and regional check-ins.
09:08–09:18	Move before you build	Wellness coach	Accessible ten-minute stretch and reset.
09:18–09:30	State of the Hackathon	MC + Mr Thulani Mabuza	Team count, challenge split, overnight highlights and Saturday milestones.
09:30–09:45	What makes a useful product?	Product leader	Build for user value, focus and adoption rather than feature volume.
09:45–10:05	From idea to viable venture	Founder + FNB SME specialist	Business model, routes to market, revenue and partnership choices.
10:05–10:20	Mentor hot seat	Dr Ronny Mabokela	Rapid answers to recurring design, code and business questions.
10:20–10:30	Sponsor Street Team live cross	Field host + sponsor representative	First doorstep delivery, participant reaction and a clue linked to an FNB, Accenture or Cloud on Demand prize.
10:30–10:45	Saturday challenge briefing	Dr Khanyisile Twabu	Explain prototype bingo, social scavenger hunt and afternoon check gate.
10:45–11:00	Closing and co-sponsor prize flash	MC + sponsor representatives	Accenture or Cloud on Demand spin-to-win draw and handover to Sonke build rooms.
11:00 - 12:00	Hack-Away	Teams with Mentors	Teams at work with the guidance of mentors
12:00 - 12:30	**SUBMISSION DEADLINE:**	**Teams**	**Teams are expected to submit/update their SSDLC – talking through how they have thought through security aspects as a team**

12:30 - 13:30	Hack-Away	Teams	Teams continue working
13:30	**SUBMISSION DEADLINE: 20 seconds Pitch View (HustleWindow)**	All teams	All teams are required to submit a 20 seconds pitch video – selling the app to the panel, who are emulating a driver in a traffic light
14:00 - 17:00	**HustleWindow – panel feedback**	**Special panels**	**Feedback will be received into email and the team page page (click MENTOR FEEDBACKS)**
17:00 - 23:00	Hack-Away	Teams	Teams at work with help from mentors
23:00 - 00:00	**Progress Update**	**Teams**	**Expected update on how far teams are in building up their solution**

DAY 3: 25 October 2026

Time	Segment	Lead	Purpose / production notes
09:00-09:08	Final-day countdown	MC + DJ	Social wall, team energy check and submission clock.
09:08-09:18	Reset and focus	Wellness coach	Short mobility and breathing session.
09:18-09:30	State of the Hackathon	Ms Yolisa Dumezweni	Progress recap, technical notices and Sunday deadlines.
09:30-09:45	Pitch with proof	Pitch coach	Show the user, problem, product, evidence, impact and ask.
09:45-10:00	Demo without drama	Tumi	Submission formats, cloud readiness, backup video, links, permissions and final checks.
10:00-10:15	Judging decoded	TBC	Explain scoring and common weaknesses. No new criteria introduced.

10:15-10:25	Street Team weekend montage	Field producer	Delivery reactions and participant stories from across the route.
10:25-10:35	Final co-sponsor prize draw	MC + sponsor representatives	Draw an Accenture or Cloud on Demand prize from teams that passed both progress gates on Sonke.
10:35-2:00	Hack-Away	Teams with mentors	Teams at work with guidance of mentors
12:00-12:30	**SUBMISSION DEADLINE: Lean Business Canvas**	**Teams**	**Teams expected to submit/update their Lean Business Canvas – talking through aspects on how marketable their solution is**
12:30-17:00	Hack-Away	Teams with Mentors	Final sprint with mentors
17:00-17:30	Final State of the Hackathon Update	Mr Tiyani Nghonyama	Final update on the hackathon and next steps

DAY 4: 26 October 2026

On your own (no mentors support) - race to submit by 23:59